The Quiet Light

Chapter One

The lighthouse keeper woke before dawn, as he always did, and listened to the sea. Some mornings it was quiet enough to hear the gulls arguing on the rocks; other mornings it roared like a train that never quite arrived.

He kept a notebook by the window. In it he wrote the colour of the sky, the direction of the wind, and the names of the ships that passed. Nobody had asked him to do this. He simply liked knowing that the days were not all the same.

On the first Tuesday of the month, a small boat brought supplies: flour, lamp oil, letters, and sometimes a newspaper already a week old. He read the newspaper slowly, a page each evening, so that the news would last until the next boat came.

“You should get a radio,” said the boatman once. The keeper thought about it for a long time. “Then I would know everything at once,” he said, “and I would have nothing left to look forward to.”

Chapter Two

Winter arrived early that year. The windows rattled in their frames and frost drew ferns across the glass. He wrapped the old brass lens in a blanket at night, though he knew it made no difference to the cold.

In the evenings he practised reading aloud. His voice had grown rusty from disuse, and he worried that one day, when someone finally came to visit, he would have forgotten how to speak. So he read to the lamp, to the kettle, and to the cat who had arrived one stormy night and decided to stay.

The cat did not care for poetry, but it listened closely to recipes.

Chapter Three — Two Columns

This page is laid out in two columns, like a magazine. A good reader should finish the whole left column before moving to the right one, instead of jumping across the page line by line.

The keeper's notebook grew thick over the years. Its pages recorded storms with names and storms without them, ships that waved and ships that did not, and one remarkable afternoon when a whale surfaced close enough to the rocks that he could hear it breathe.

If you are hearing this sentence, the left column has been read in the right order. Now the reader should continue at the top of the right-hand column.

Welcome to the right-hand column. In spring the boatman brought a surprise: a small radio, wrapped in brown paper and tied with string. The keeper thanked him, put it on the shelf, and never once switched it on.

“Why keep it, then?” asked the boatman, the following year. The keeper smiled. “Because now I choose,” he said, “every single evening, to listen to the sea instead.”

And that is the end of this short sample book. If the last word of this sentence was highlighted, everything is working.